discourses in various parts of the monastery and in the temples across. According to Xuanzang's biographer, Hwui Li, 'Within the temple they arrange every day about 100 pulpits for preaching, and the students attend these discourses without any fail.'

Nalanda relied on royal patrons for its sustenance, including famous names like the Guptas of Magadh, Harsha of Kannauj and the Palas of Bengal. Seals and inscriptions on bricks, stone and copper plates at Nalanda have revealed other names too, such as the seventh-century Maukhari Dynasty of Magadh and Bhaskaravarma, a king from Assam. They variously commissioned new monasteries, temples, or gave grants of money, livestock or land. Taxes raised from all villages on this land flowed to Nalanda (Xuanzang reports 100 villages, Yijing 201), including essentials like food, clothing, lodging and medicine for all students and teachers. Each day, villagers sent 'several hundred piculs of ordinary rice' (1 picul = 60 kg), and 'several hundred catties in weight of butter and milk' (1 catty = 100 kg) to Nalanda. Though these numbers appear too large as well, this generous aid, according to Xuanzang, 'is the source of the perfection of their studies'.

One king built a high wall around the Mahavihara, likely something the monks had desired for a while. 'A long succession of kings,' writes Xuanzang, 'continued the work of building, using all the skill of the sculptor, till the whole is truly marvelous to behold.' In the ninth century, even a king of Sumatra, Balaputra, 'built a monastery at Nalanda and provided funds for the acquisition of five villages, the income from which would support the monastery'.[8]

In physical terms, Nalanda Mahavihara evolved a good deal over the centuries. Most of its structures were even rebuilt multiple times, sometimes after a fire. New layers appeared on top of old remains, often with new architectural features and sculptural decor. The monastic complex extended beyond today's ASI boundaries to neighbouring mounds that still await excavation, although some have been pillaged over the centuries for their bricks.

Sculptures excavated at Nalanda are in stucco, stone and bronze. A great many are of the Buddha himself, showing a range of poses or mudras and iconic events from his life. Bodhisattvas appear too, as well as Jambhala,